getting any wickets?’ I switch off the side of me that wants to get over emotional, take the breath at my mark and go into assassin mode. I bowl Ryan Harris first ball, turning round, arms wide in a crucifix and then look at Mitchell, putting my fingers to my lips to shush him. It has been captured in one, swooping cinematic shot on television. I’m not aware when it happens that it will likely be the defining moment of my cricket career. It’s just one incident of many on a cricket pitch, constantly a battlefield with this kind of interaction flashing through it, minute after minute.

This team, developing over a number of years, is at their peak – a mixture of rock-hard resilient cricketers, all bristling with a tension that pushes the team beyond their history, an accepting of our limits and then pushing against them, a collective, ever-increasing will, carrying around symbolic bricks as sacrifice. We bat time. Alastair Cook – a destined great, is in form like no other batter I have ever seen. Andrew Strauss – a leader now of extreme knowledge and dexterity. Jonathan Trott – a collection of ticks and processes smoothed out into an unbeatable anchor. Kevin Pietersen – the alpha in the pack, dominant and expressive and a figure of fear for oppositions everywhere. Ian Bell – now a fully formed, multi-dimensional batter with the most aesthetically pleasing cover drive in the world. Paul Collingwood – a survivor, a man who finds a way in all he does. Matt Prior – a wicketkeeper with a desperation to win, a fierce loyalty to his team and a record fast approaching the best in his position.

Then there’s the unit of bowlers with our responsibilities exactly chiselled, each certain of their roles and at the best they’ve ever been. Stuart Broad – now developing a knack of taking wickets when they are needed most, to burst teams open with moments like he has just flicked a switch. Tim Bresnan – a devilishly fast bowler to deal with, bowling quicker than he appears, containing and attacking so that even the periods without the new ball are agonising handfuls for middle orders. Steven Finn – regularly bowling 90 miles an hour plus, his height creating excess bounce and a nightmare to judge or play. Chris Tremlett – at the peak of his game, his stature and physique perfect for Australian pitches, extracting exaggerated bounce even out of flat pitches, with a body built to keep going. Graeme Swann – the best spinner in the world, always bowling from one end, never relenting, offering effortless control and infinite wicket-taking options for Strauss.